

Eating Smart with Diabetes: The Filipino Guide

Which carbs spike blood sugar, which ones don't,
and how to **protect your kidneys & heart**

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1 in 3

Filipinos has diabetes or prediabetes

<7%

HbA1c target for most patients

30–40%

Glucose spike cut by eating order alone

1 What is the Glycemic Index (GI) — and Why It Matters for Filipinos

Low GI < 55

Slow, steady glucose rise — Eat freely · GOOD

Medium GI 56–70

Moderate glucose spike — Eat carefully · LIMIT

High GI > 70

Fast, sharp glucose spike — Limit or avoid

GL (Glycemic Load) = GI × grams of carbs per serving ÷ 100. It is more practical than GI alone because it accounts for portion size. GL <10 = Low · GL 11–19 = Medium · GL ≥20 = High. Pages 2–3 show both GI and GL for each food.

2 The Filipino Diabetes Plate

1/2

NON-STARCHY VEG

- Ampalaya / okra
- Kangkong / sitaw
- Talong / kamatis
- Malunggay / labanos

1/4

LEAN PROTEIN

- Grilled isda / tilapia
- Chicken breast
- Tokwa / monggo
- Boiled egg (1 pc)

1/4

QUALITY CARBS

- 1/2 cup brown/basmati rice
- Boiled kamote
- Rolled oats

3 Rice Strategies — Lower the GI Without Giving It Up

TIP 1

Cool overnight in fridge → resistant starch forms → lowers GI by ~20–30%. Reheat before eating.

TIP 2

Add 1 tsp calamansi juice or vinegar to the rice → acid slows starch digestion, lowers GI ~20%.

TIP 3

Eat rice LAST after vegetables and protein → blunts the post-meal glucose spike by 30–40%.

TIP 4

Switch to basmati or brown rice (GI 58–68) and keep portions to 1/2 cup cooked per meal.

TIP 5

Mix with monggo or add okra — soluble fiber slows absorption and drops the meal's overall GI.

4 Eat in the Right Order — Meal Sequencing Cuts the Spike

1st: Vegetables

Ampalaya, okra, sitaw, pinakbet first

2nd: Protein

Grilled isda, tinola chicken, tokwa, egg

3rd: Carbs Last

Rice, kamote or oats — smaller portion

↓30–40%

Post-meal spike vs. rice first

5 Your Blood Glucose Target Numbers

Know Your Numbers (ADA 2025)

Fasting Glucose

80–130

mg/dL

2-Hour Post-Meal

<180

mg/dL

HbA1c (most patients)

<7%

every 3–6 months

HbA1c (elderly/frail)

<8%

less strict target

Hypoglycemia Alert

<70

mg/dL — treat now

BP Target (w/ DM)

<130/80

mmHg

Targets are individualized — ask your doctor if you are elderly, pregnant, or have CKD or frequent hypoglycemia.

6 Simple Filipino Kitchen Swaps for Diabetes

REMOVE

White rice (3+ cups/day)

→

USE INSTEAD

1/2 cup cold/basmati rice + boiled kamote

3-in-1 coffee / softdrinks

→

Black barako coffee or salabat (no sugar)

Instant pancit canton / lugaw

→

Sotanghon soup with vegetables (GI 35)

Puto / kakanin merienda

→

1 boiled egg + 1 guava or green mango

Sweetened juice drinks (Tang, Royal)

→

Fresh calamansi juice (unsweetened) + water

Ripe mango (whole fruit)

→

Bayabas/guava or 1/2 green mango (GI 31–41)

Fried banana cue / turon

→

Boiled unripe saba (GI 52) — no sugar added

HOW TO READ PAGES 2–3: ■ AVOID = High GI >70 or High GL ≥20 ■ LIMIT = Medium GI 56–70 or GL 11–19

■ GOOD = Low GI <55 and Low GL ≤10 73 = GI value 33 = GL value

Food Item (Filipino Name)	Typical Serving	GI	GL	Rating	Key Note
A · BIGAS AT BUTIL — RICE & STAPLE GRAINS					
White rice, steamed (kanin)	1 cup cooked	73	33	AVOID	Biggest blood sugar spike in the Filipino diet; replace with ½ cup brown/basmati rice + kamote
Glutinous rice / malagkit (biko)	½ cup cooked	98	34	AVOID	Highest GI staple in Filipino cuisine; near-pure amylopectin starch — rapid glucose release
Lugaw / arroz caldo (rice porridge)	1 bowl 300 mL	78	20	AVOID	Over-cooking breaks starch into simple glucose; spikes faster than steamed rice; try oatmeal instead
Brown rice (pilit na kayumanggi)	1 cup cooked	68	31	LIMIT	Only slightly lower GI than white; main benefit is fiber and micronutrients; still needs portion control
Basmati rice (aged, cooked)	1 cup cooked	58	26	LIMIT	Best rice variety for diabetes; long-chain amylose digests more slowly — keep to ½ cup per meal
Rolled oats, soaked overnight	½ cup dry	42	11	GOOD	Best breakfast carb; beta-glucan soluble fiber blunts glucose rise; do NOT add condensed milk
Monggo / green mung bean (boiled)	1 cup cooked	31	11	GOOD	Excellent low-GI protein + fiber staple; sauté with malunggay in canola oil for a diabetes-friendly meal
Red kidney beans / munggo pula	1 cup cooked	24	8	GOOD	Very low GI; high in resistant starch and protein; use in soups as a rice replacement
B · TINAPAY AT MIE — BREAD, PASTA & NOODLES					
White bread (Gardenia, Bimbo)	2 slices	71	20	AVOID	Digested almost as fast as white rice; refined flour → rapid glucose spike; choose whole grain instead
Instant noodles (Pancit Canton)	1 pack	72	28	AVOID	Palm-oil fried noodles + very high sodium + MSG; double hit of high GI + high GL; worst noodle choice
Puto (steamed white rice cake)	3 pieces	75	22	AVOID	Refined rice starch, rapidly digested; popular merienda but spikes blood sugar quickly
Whole wheat bread (fibrous)	2 slices	69	16	LIMIT	Marginally better than white; check label — “wheat flour” ≠ whole grain; look for “whole wheat” first
Pasta / spaghetti (al dente, plain)	1 cup cooked	57	22	LIMIT	Al dente = lower GI; overcooking raises GI; avoid sweet Filipino-style spaghetti sauce
Sotanghon / glass noodles	½ cup cooked	35	10	GOOD	Best noodle for diabetes; mung bean starch is naturally low GI; use in soup with vegetables and chicken
Bihon rice noodles (steamed)	½ cup cooked	40	12	GOOD	Lower GI than wheat pasta; avoid stir-fried pancit with sweet soy sauce — adds sugar fast
C · ROOT CROPS AT STARCHY VEG — ROOT CROPS & STARCHY VEGETABLES					
Kalabasa / pumpkin (boiled)	1 cup	75	13	AVOID	Very high GI despite low GL; eat only small portions combined with protein to blunt spike
Cassava / kamoteng kahoy (boiled)	½ cup	65	15	LIMIT	Medium GI; avoid processed cassava (cassava cake, nilupak with sugar) — GI becomes very high
Corn on the cob / mais (boiled)	1 medium cob	59	12	LIMIT	Whole corn better than cornstarch; fiber intact; avoid corn syrup products; good occasional merienda
Kamote / sweet potato (boiled)	1 medium 150g	44	12	GOOD	Best root crop for diabetes; boiling is key — baking raises GI to 94; rich in fiber and potassium
Gabi / taro (boiled, plain)	½ cup	54	8	GOOD	Good low-GI root crop; use in sinigang instead of potato; avoid gabi desserts with sugar or coconut cream
D · PRUTAS — FRUITS					
Watermelon (pakwan)	2 cups cubed	80	8	AVOID	Very high GI despite low GL; fast glucose release; choose guava or green mango instead
Very ripe mango / hinog na mangga	1 medium	73	17	AVOID	The riper, the higher the GI; at peak ripeness fructose and glucose spike blood sugar fast
Lanzones, lychee, rambutan	10 pieces	72	15	AVOID	High simple sugar content; easy to over-eat; limit to 5 pieces maximum if eaten with protein
Ripe mango (firm), half portion	½ small mango	60	14	LIMIT	High fructose even at medium GI; limit to ½ small mango; eat with protein to slow absorption
Papaya (ripe, hinog na papaya)	1 cup cubed	59	8	LIMIT	Moderate GI but low GL; reasonable in portions; enzyme papain may modestly aid glucose metabolism
Pineapple / pinya (fresh)	½ cup	66	9	LIMIT	Higher GI than expected; bromelain enzyme may have modest benefits; limit to small portions
Bayabas / guava (green-yellow)	1 medium	31	4	GOOD	Highest fiber of all Philippine fruits; excellent for blood sugar control; eat 1–2 daily as merienda
Green mango / hilaw na mangga	1 small	41	5	GOOD	Same fruit as ripe mango — but low GI when unripe; very popular and diabetes-friendly
Avocado / abokado	½ medium	15	1	GOOD	Near-zero carb; rich in heart-healthy monounsaturated fat; pairs well with rice to lower overall GI
Dalandan / ponkan / suha (citrus)	1 medium	38	5	GOOD	Slow-releasing fructose + vitamin C; eat whole fruit — juice removes fiber and concentrates sugars

Food Item (Filipino Name)	Typical Serving	GI	GL	Rating	Key Note
E · GULAY — NON-STARCHY VEGETABLES · EAT FREELY · LOW GI ALWAYS					
Ampalaya / bitter melon	1 cup	17	1	GOOD	Traditional diabetes superfood; charantin and polypeptide-p have documented glucose-lowering effects
Okra (steamed or in sinigang)	1 cup	20	2	GOOD	Viscous mucilage fiber slows glucose absorption in the gut; eat daily — best vegetable for diabetes
Malunggay / moringa (leaves)	½ cup	20	1	GOOD	Rich in quercetin and chlorogenic acid; modestly lowers blood sugar; add to tinola, sinigang, or monggo
Kangkong / water spinach (ginisa)	1 cup	15	1	GOOD	Abundant and affordable; sauté in canola oil + garlic; excellent iron and vitamin source
Sitaw · talong · labanos	1 cup	28	3	GOOD	All low-GI vegetables; fill half the plate with these before eating rice; no quantity restriction
Pinakbet (canola oil, no bagoong)	1 cup	22	3	GOOD	Ideal Filipino diabetes dish; okra + ampalaya + talong; skip bagoong (sodium) and lard
Kalabasa / pumpkin (in sinigang)	½ cup	75	7	LIMIT	High GI but very low GL in normal portion; always eat with protein in a full meal to blunt impact
F · PROTINA AT LEGUMES — PROTEINS & LEGUMES					
Galunggong / round scad (grilled)	2–3 pieces	0	0	GOOD	Best budget omega-3 fish in PH; no glycemic impact; grill or steam — avoid frying in coconut oil
Tilapia / bangus (grilled/steamed)	1 medium	0	0	GOOD	Zero GI; lean protein that slows glucose absorption when eaten before carbs; eat daily
Sardinas sa kamatis (canned)	1 can	5	0	GOOD	Affordable omega-3; zero glycemic load; choose tomato sauce — NOT oil; watch sodium in CKD
Chicken breast, grilled (no skin)	1 piece	0	0	GOOD	Zero GI; the quarter-plate protein; tinola with malunggay is one of the best diabetic Filipino meals
Tokwa / firm tofu (steamed)	½ block	15	1	GOOD	Plant protein; replaces pork in adobo and scrambles; soy protein modestly improves insulin sensitivity
Boiled egg (itlog)	1 large	0	0	GOOD	Zero carbs; excellent merienda protein; limit to 1/day if LDL is also elevated
Longganisa / tocino (sweet-cured)	2 links	45	5	LIMIT	Added sugar in cure raises GI for a "protein" food; high sat fat + sodium compound cardiovascular risk
Lechon / chicharon / pork skin	100g	0	0	AVOID	GI is zero but saturated fat impairs insulin sensitivity over time; worsens CKD and cardiovascular risk
G · INUMIN — BEVERAGES					
Softdrinks (Coke, Sprite, Royal)	1 can 330 mL	65	26	AVOID	35–40g sugar per can; liquid glucose has almost no delay — one can ≈ nearly 3 tsp of sugar direct
3-in-1 coffee (Nescafe, Kopiko)	1 sachet	70	18	AVOID	Non-dairy creamer (palm-oil fat) + sugar = simultaneous fat + carb spike; switch to black brewed barako
Powdered juice (Tang, Zesto)	1 glass 250 mL	68	22	AVOID	Pure sugar + artificial color + no nutrients; one of the largest contributors to diabetes in Filipino diet
Commercial fruit juice (Minute Maid)	1 glass 250 mL	68	19	AVOID	Fiber removed; fructose concentrated; spikes blood sugar almost like sweetened drinks despite "fruit" label
Milo / Ovaltine (2 tsp powder)	1 cup	55	14	LIMIT	Moderate sugar; use only 1 tsp powder with skim milk; never add condensed milk; limit to once/day
Buko / coconut juice (no sugar)	1 coconut	55	11	LIMIT	Natural sugars; potassium-rich; acceptable if renal function is normal; avoid bottled sweetened versions
Black coffee / barako (no sugar)	1–2 cups	0	0	GOOD	Zero GI; chlorogenic acid improves insulin sensitivity; 2 cups/day associated with lower T2DM risk
Salabat / ginger tea (no arnibal)	1 cup	5	0	GOOD	Gingerol improves insulin signaling; ideal post-meal drink; anti-inflammatory; traditional remedy
Unsweetened calamansi juice	1 glass + water	30	2	GOOD	Vitamin C; low sugar when no arnibal added; also lowers GI of rice when added directly to cooked rice
H · KAKANIN AT MATAMIS — FILIPINO SWEETS & DESSERTS					
Biko / sinukmani (malagkit + gata)	1 piece	95	48	AVOID	Highest GI and GL of all Filipino sweets; malagkit + coconut cream + brown sugar = triple spike trigger
Leche flan	1 slice 100g	62	30	AVOID	Egg yolk + condensed milk + sugar = very high GL per slice; spikes blood sugar quickly
Halo-halo (full serving)	1 large glass	80	36	AVOID	Condensed milk + ube ice cream + arnibal + sweetened beans = multiple sugar layers; worst dessert for DM
Maja blanca / bibingka / champorado	1 serving	72	24	AVOID	All high-GI, high-GL Filipino desserts; refined carb + sugar + coconut cream combination to avoid
White sugar / arnibal / condensed milk	1 tsp / 2 tbsp	65+	14+	AVOID	Pure glucose/fructose; remove from drinks, rice, condiments; stevia or monk fruit are zero-GI alternatives
Boiled saba banana (unripe)	2 pieces	52	14	LIMIT	Resistant starch when slightly unripe; do NOT fry or add sugar; eat as merienda with 1 boiled egg
Puto (plain, small)	2 pieces	68	15	LIMIT	Lower fat than most kakanin but still high refined carb; if eaten, pair with protein, keep to 2 small pieces
Bayabas / guava (fresh, as dessert)	1–2 medium	31	4	GOOD	Best dessert after any Filipino meal; high fiber, high vitamin C, very low GL; eat instead of kakanin

🍽️ 7-Day Filipino Diabetes Meal Plan — ½ Veg · ¼ Protein · ¼ Carbs · Eat in Order

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Merienda	Dinner
Mon	Quaker oatmeal + boiled egg + black barako coffee	Sinigang na tilapia + ½ cup cold rice + pinakbet (okra + talong)	1 guava + 1 boiled egg	Monggo guisado with malunggay + boiled kamote (no rice)
Tue	Ginisang ampalaya at itlog + ½ cup brown rice + salabat	Tinolang manok (breast, no skin, with malunggay) + ½ cup rice	Green mango + 30g pili nuts	Inihaw na bangus (no skin) + ginisang kangkong + ½ cup basmati rice
Wed	Overnight oats (calamansi, no sugar) + dalandan	Sardinas sa kamatis + sitaw at kalabasa guisado + ½ cup cold rice	2 boiled saba (unripe) + salabat	Chicken adobo sa puti (breast, no skin) + steamed labanos + ½ cup rice
Thu	Scrambled tokwa + tomato + black coffee (no sugar)	Grilled galunggong + pinakbet (canola oil, no bagoong) + ½ cup rice	1–2 guavas fresh	Monggo at dilis + kangkong + boiled kamote instead of rice
Fri	Oatmeal + 1 boiled egg + calamansi juice (unsweetened)	Sinigang na bangus sa sampalok + okra + talong + ½ cup rice	½ avocado + water	Steamed tilapia + malunggay soup + sotanghon guisado (no sugar)
Sat	Scrambled egg + tomato + brown rice (½ cup) + black coffee	Paksiw na bangus (light vinegar, no pork) + sitaw + ½ cup cold rice	Ponkan + 1 boiled egg	Lumpiang sariwa (fresh, not fried) + tokwa filling + ½ cup rice
Sun	Overnight oats + sliced green mango (no sugar) + salabat	Nilagang manok (breast only) + malunggay + boiled kamote (no rice)	1 guava + water	Sardinas + ampalaya con huevo (1 egg) + ½ cup basmati rice

Diabetes Medications & Food Interactions	
Metformin	Take WITH meals to avoid nausea. Long-term use depletes Vitamin B12 — check B12 yearly. No food causes a dangerous interaction.
Sulfonylureas (glibenclamide, glipizide)	MUST eat within 30 min of taking the tablet. Skipping or delaying meals → hypoglycemia risk. Keep sugar (3 pcs candy) on hand.
SGLT2 Inhibitors (empagliflozin, dapagliflozin)	Drink 6–8 glasses water/day (glucose lost via urine → dehydration risk). Reduce rice and sugar for best effect. Avoid if UTI active.
GLP-1 Agonists (semaglutide, dulaglutide)	Nausea worsens with high-fat meals (lechon, gata). Eat small, low-fat meals. Avoid large rice portions — delays gastric emptying further.
Insulin	Keep carb intake consistent at each meal (same rice amount daily). Skipping or late meals → hypo/hyperglycemia. Never skip a meal after rapid insulin.

Lifestyle Changes That Lower HbA1c	
🚶 Walk After Meals ↓ Post-meal glucose 10–15% Even 10 minutes of brisk walking after eating significantly lowers the 2-hour glucose spike. Do it after lunch and dinner.	⚖️ Lose 5–7% Body Weight ↓ HbA1c 0.5–1% In prediabetes, 5–7% weight loss prevents progression to diabetes in 58% of cases. Focus on rice portions first.
✂️ Cut Rice in Half Fastest HbA1c drop Reducing white rice from 3 cups to 1 cup/day is often the single most impactful diet change for Filipino patients.	😴 Sleep 7–8 Hours Improves insulin sensitivity Sleep deprivation raises cortisol and glucose. Poor sleep can raise fasting glucose by 10–15 mg/dL.
⚠️ Special Situations Fasting (religious): Consult your doctor first. Sulfonylurea/insulin doses must be adjusted. Eat suhur with low-GI foods (oatmeal, monggo). Break fast with dates + water, then protein before carbs. Sick day: Never skip diabetes medications when ill. Monitor glucose every 4–6 hours. Drink clear fluids. Contact your doctor if glucose >300 mg/dL or you cannot eat.	